MINNEAPOLIS, UNITED STATES

Minneapolis Institute of Art: Masterpieces

Twenty works in which a stain, a brushstroke or a slight change of colour carries the argument.



The blood on Lucretia's pale clothing changes how everything else in Rembrandt's painting is read. Van Gogh's olive grove makes a different demand: ground, trees and sky are distinct, yet related kinds of strokes keep movement running through them all. At the other end of this selection, Ad Reinhardt asks for attention to differences close enough to black that a quick glance may miss them.

These are three very different uses of a painted surface. This guide follows them through portraits, landscapes and a theatrical scroll at the Minneapolis Institute of Art. Sometimes paint clarifies an object; sometimes it complicates recognition. The useful question is not whether a picture looks realistic, but which distinctions its handling makes possible.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/minneapolis-institute-art

The selection · 20

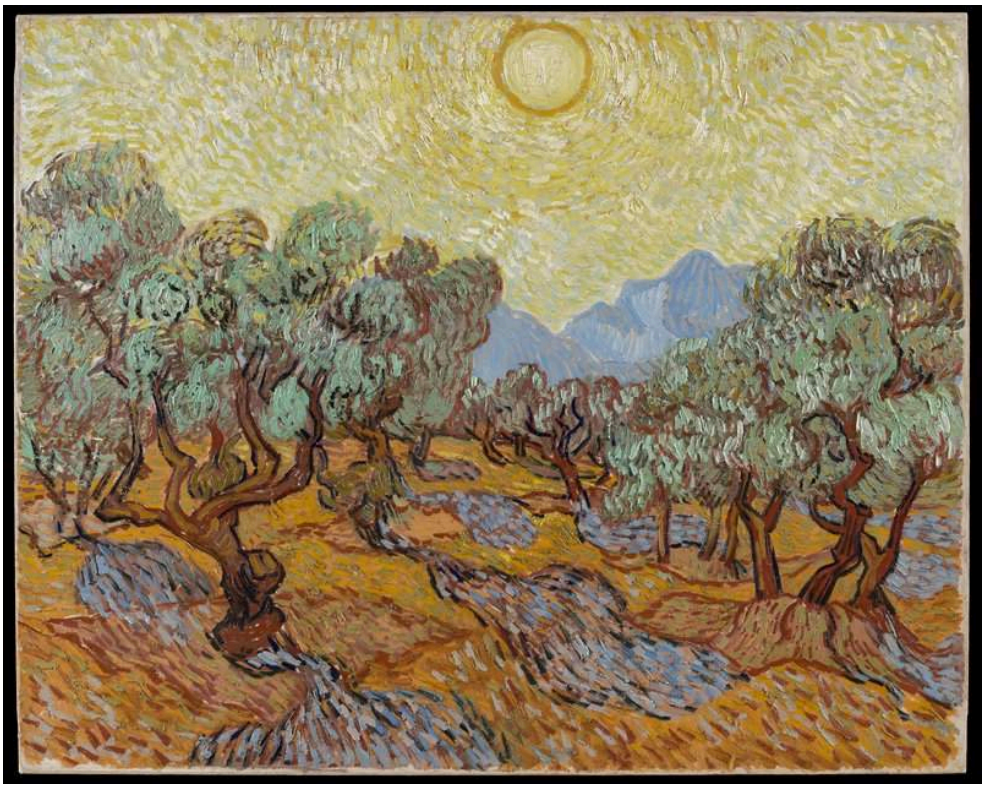
1. Olive Trees
   Vincent van Gogh · 1889
2. Lucretia
   Rembrandt van Rijn · 1666
3. Hortense Valpinçon
   Edgar Degas · c. 1871
4. The Japanese Bridge
   Claude Monet · c. 1923–25
5. The Mill Stream, Montclair, New Jersey
   George Inness · c. 1888
6. The Death of Germanicus
   Nicolas Poussin · 1627
7. City Night
   Georgia O'Keeffe · 1926
8. Our Nurse, Margaret Burgess
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9. Self-Portrait with Dr Arrieta
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10. Under the Pandanus
    Paul Gauguin · 1891
11. White Plumes
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15. A Pond in the Morvan
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16. A Scene on the Tohickon Creek: Autumn
    Thomas Moran · 1868
17. A Vestal Virgin Tending Fire
    François Lemoyne · c. 1726–27
18. Abstract Painting No. 9
    Ad Reinhardt · 1960–66
19. Abundant Fruit
    Severin Roesen · 1858
20. Ichikawa Danjūrō V in a Shibaraku Role
    Katsukawa Shunshō · c. 1788

01 / 20

Olive Trees

Vincent van Gogh

1889 · Oil on canvas · Minneapolis Institute of Art



Vincent van Gogh. Olive Trees. Image credit: Minneapolis Institute of Art, The William Hood Dunwoody Fund. Public Domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public Domain

The twisted trees remain separate from the ochre ground, but the strokes running through both give them related forms of activity. Van Gogh does not reserve movement for foliage stirred by weather. Sky and earth participate too. The blue mountains steady the distance, allowing the densely worked foreground to remain legible as a rooted grove rather than an undifferentiated pattern.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 51.7

02 / 20

Lucretia

Rembrandt van Rijn

1666 · Oil on canvas · Minneapolis Institute of Art



Rembrandt van Rijn. Lucretia. Image credit: Minneapolis Institute of Art, The William Hood Dunwoody Fund. Public Domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public Domain

The stain on the undergarment places this moment after Lucretia has wounded herself. Rembrandt gives her no triumphant gesture: the lowered gaze and hand raised towards a cord keep attention on a vulnerable body. The ancient story has often served public ideas of honour. Here its consequence is concentrated in cloth, blood and the effort required simply to remain upright.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 34.19

03 / 20

Hortense Valpinçon

Edgar Degas

c. 1871 · Oil on mattress ticking · Minneapolis Institute of Art



Edgar Degas. Portrait of Mlle. Hortense Valpinçon. Image credit: Minneapolis Institute of Art, The John R. Van Derlip Fund. Public Domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public Domain

The girl's leaning pose interrupts the room's busy patterns. Degas gives her enough informality to appear occupied in her own setting, while the turned head keeps her available to the portrait. Flowers and furnishings could easily dominate such a small figure. Instead, their density makes her particular arrangement of hands, shoulders and face a clearer point of attention.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 48.1

04 / 20

The Japanese Bridge

Claude Monet

c. 1923–25 · Oil on canvas · Minneapolis Institute of Art



Claude Monet. The Japanese Bridge. Image credit: Minneapolis Institute of Art, Bequest of Putnam Dana McMillan. Public Domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public Domain

The bridge has to be found within dense red, blue, yellow and green marks. In this late Monet, familiar architecture no longer provides a clean outline around which colour can be arranged. Recognition depends on a few surviving relations. The garden remains the subject, but the painting gives unusual weight to the point at which a known place becomes difficult to separate from paint.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 61.36.15

05 / 20

The Mill Stream, Montclair, New Jersey

George Inness

c. 1888 · Oil on canvas · Minneapolis Institute of Art



George Inness. The Mill Stream, Montclair, New Jersey. George Inness; Minneapolis Institute of Art; Gift of Don and Diana Lee Lucker. Public Domain Mark 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

Roofs and chimneys remain visible beyond the thin trees, even as warm light softens their separation from the landscape. Inness does not need to remove industry to achieve continuity. The blurred reflections help join built and natural forms within the same atmosphere. Look for where an edge remains firm and where it yields: that variation carries the view's coherence.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2000.236

06 / 20

The Death of Germanicus

Nicolas Poussin

1627 · Oil on canvas · Minneapolis Institute of Art



The Death of Germanicus. WikiArt; Nicolas Poussin. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Extended arms connect the dying man's bed with the soldiers, while the family occupies another part of the gathering. Poussin keeps different responses legible rather than making grief a single repeated expression. Deep blue drapery holds the scene together above them. Public obligation and private loss share a room, but the figures' positions prevent those experiences from becoming interchangeable.

Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

City Night

Georgia O'Keeffe

1926 · Oil on canvas · Minneapolis Institute of Art



Georgia O'Keeffe. City Night. Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

O'Keeffe leaves only a narrow interval of sky between the rising buildings. From this upward angle, the city is less a collection of addresses than a structure enclosing the observer. A small light near the lower edge sharpens the difference in scale. The broad dark masses make height palpable without requiring windows or street activity to be described individually.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 80.28

08 / 20

Our Nurse, Margaret Burgess

Florine Stettheimer

1929 · Oil on canvas · Minneapolis Institute of Art



Florine Stettheimer. Portrait of Our Nurse, Margaret Burgess. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Stettheimer names the household worker and gives her an elongated, central presence within a setting of small objects and figures. Scale follows the painting's decorative arrangement rather than a consistently measured room. The title's possessive phrase records a household relationship, but Margaret Burgess is not reduced to an anonymous function. Her name anchors the invented world around her.

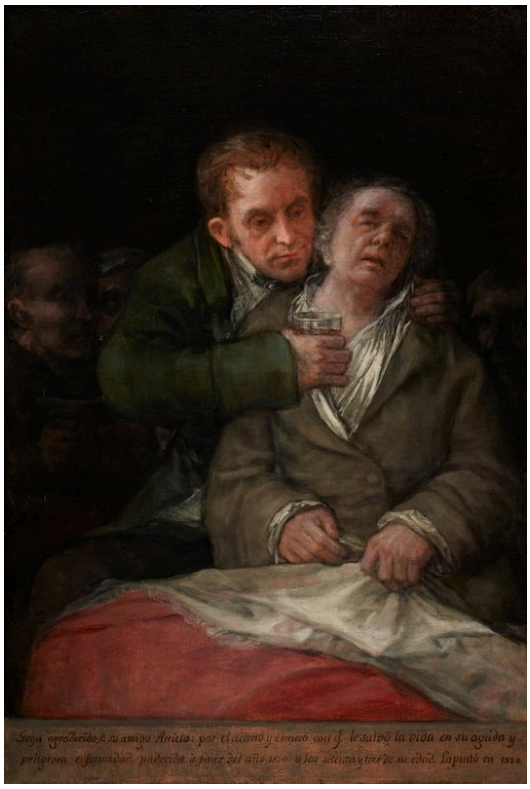
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 59.21

09 / 20

Self-Portrait with Dr Arrieta

Francisco Goya

1820 · Oil on canvas · Minneapolis Institute of Art



Francisco Goya. Self-Portrait with Dr. Arrieta. Image credit: Minneapolis Institute of Art, The Ethel Morrison Van Derlip Fund. Public Domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public Domain

Goya represents himself unable to maintain the self-sufficient pose of a conventional portrait. Arrieta supports him and brings a glass towards his mouth. The doctor's practical action gives the image its structure: one body makes the other's position possible. The shadowy company behind them cannot compete with this specific account of care at close quarters.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 52.14

10 / 20

Under the Pandanus

Paul Gauguin

1891 · Oil on canvas · Minneapolis Institute of Art



Paul Gauguin. I Raro Te Oviri (Under the Pandanus). Image credit: Minneapolis Institute of Art, The William Hood Dunwoody Fund. Public Domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public Domain

Purple ground and patterned foliage give the setting an order that does not depend on naturalistic colour. Gauguin places the women and dark animal within that constructed field. Its visual coherence should not be confused with a transparent account of Tahitian life. The painting shows, among other things, a European artist deciding how a place and its people will appear.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 41.4

11 / 20

White Plumes

Henri Matisse

1919 · Oil on canvas · Minneapolis Institute of Art



Henri Matisse. White Plumes. Image credit: Minneapolis Institute of Art, The William Hood Dunwoody Fund. Public Domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public Domain

The feathered hat spreads well beyond the head, giving an accessory much of the portrait's pictorial weight. Matisse balances it against the red background, dark hair and pale clothing. The sitter's face must hold its place within this competition of shapes. Costume is therefore more than information about fashion; it changes the proportions through which the person is seen.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 47.41

12 / 20

Self-Portrait with a Detachable Collar

Frédéric Bazille

1865–67 · Oil on canvas · Minneapolis Institute of Art



Frédéric Bazille. Self-Portrait with Detachable Collar. Frédéric Bazille; Minneapolis Institute of Art; The John R. Van Derlip Fund. Public Domain Mark 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

A narrow white collar separates Bazille's head from the darker jacket and background. With so few bright accents available, that small piece of clothing acquires structural importance. The slightly turned face can emerge without a studio, palette or other explanatory prop. The likeness depends on measured differences of tone rather than an inventory of the painter's profession.

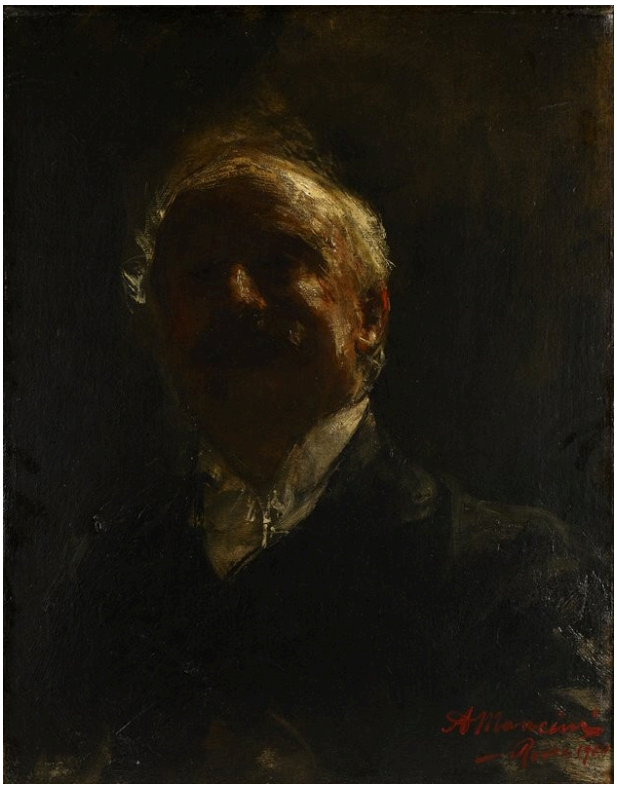
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 62.39

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Self-Portrait

Antonio Mancini

1910 · Oil on canvas · Minneapolis Institute of Art



Antonio Mancini. Self-Portrait. Antonio Mancini; Minneapolis Institute of Art; The Putnam Dana McMillan Fund; 71.50. Public Domain Mark 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

Mancini's face emerges unevenly, broken by rough highlights and areas that remain in shadow. The paint does not offer every feature with the same clarity. Recognition persists despite these omissions, making the process of finding a face part of looking at the portrait. Compare Bazille's clean collar: two small self-images can set very different conditions for becoming visible.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 71.50

14 / 20

Saint Anthony Falls as It Appeared in 1848

Henry Lewis

1855 · Oil on canvas · Minneapolis Institute of Art



Henry Lewis. St. Anthony Falls as It Appeared in 1848. Henry Lewis; Minneapolis Institute of Art; Gift of E. C. Gale; 28.79. Public Domain Mark 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The date in Lewis's title belongs to the scene represented, not to the painting's manufacture in 1855. That distinction gives this river view a retrospective character. Falls, islands, trees and low buildings record a particular state of the site. The broad arrangement remains a composed landscape, even while the title asks it to serve as a historical account.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 28.79

15 / 20

A Pond in the Morvan

Charles-François Daubigny

1869 · Oil on canvas · Minneapolis Institute of Art



Charles-François Daubigny. A Pond in the Morvan. Charles-François Daubigny; Minneapolis Institute of Art; Gift of Mr. M. R. Schweitzer. Public Domain Mark 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

Daubigny holds water and dense trees together through closely related tones. There is no conspicuous central event to organise the view, so the differences between the dark foreground, pond and warmer light become its main divisions. The scene's stillness has been constructed, not merely found. A few broad masses give the eye enough variation to remain engaged.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 71.66

16 / 20

A Scene on the Tohickon Creek: Autumn

Thomas Moran

1868 · Oil on canvas · Minneapolis Institute of Art



Thomas Moran. A Scene on the Tohickon Creek: Autumn. Thomas Moran; Minneapolis Institute of Art; The Frances E. Andrews Wilderness Fund, in memory of her mother Mary Hunt Andrews; 68.82. Public Domain Mark 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The creek opens a passage through trees that might otherwise close into a continuous wall. Moran uses small falls and lighter areas of water to carry attention towards the brighter distance. The autumn foliage supplies warmth, but the stream supplies movement through the picture. Following it reveals how a crowded landscape can be made traversable to the eye.

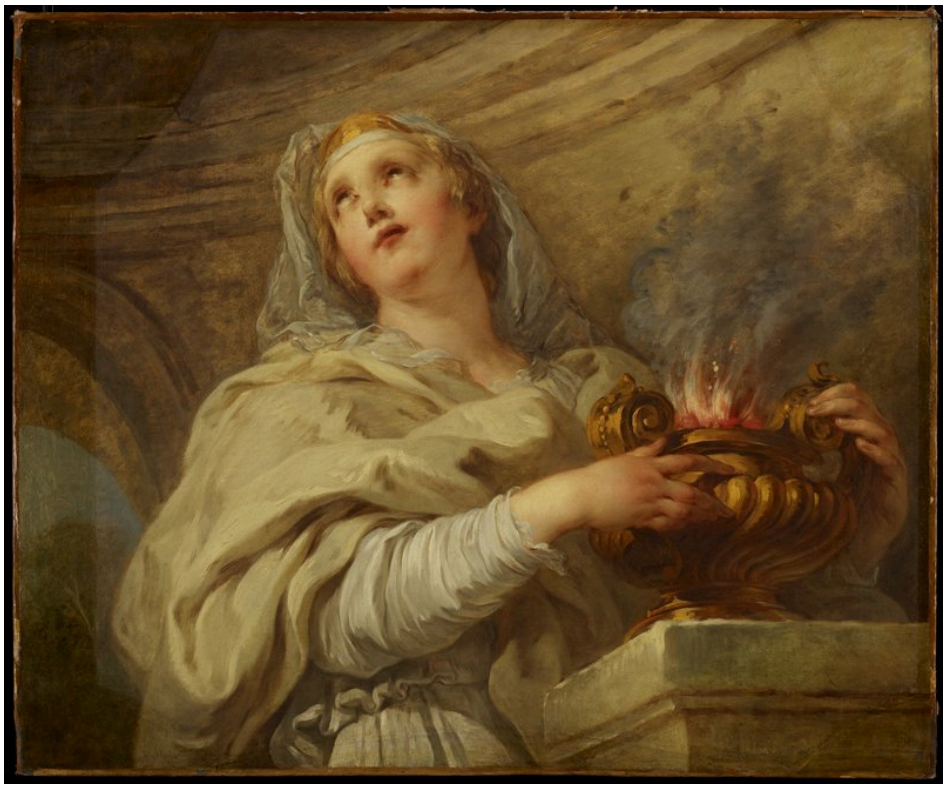
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 68.82

17 / 20

A Vestal Virgin Tending Fire

François Lemoyne

c. 1726–27 · Oil on canvas · Minneapolis Institute of Art



François Lemoyne. A Vestal Virgin Tending Fire. François Lemoyne; Minneapolis Institute of Art; The Ethel Morrison Van Derlip Fund; 65.48. Public Domain Mark 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The flame identifies the woman's ritual responsibility and lights the figure who tends it. Lemoyne brings the action close enough for the face and hands to become its principal measures. An object can have this double function without requiring an elaborate symbolic explanation: the small fire is the reason for her presence and the means by which that presence is revealed.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 65.48

18 / 20

Abstract Painting No. 9

Ad Reinhardt

1960–66 · Oil on canvas · Minneapolis Institute of Art



Ad Reinhardt. Abstract Painting No. 9. WikiArt source label: Ad Reinhardt Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/ad-reinhardt/abstract-painting-no-9-1966 · Ad Reinhardt Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The nearly black rectangles do not immediately separate themselves from their dark surroundings. Reinhardt removes the strong contrast that usually makes a composition quickly readable. Looking requires time for slight differences to emerge. A screen reproduction can suppress or exaggerate those differences, so the image should not be treated as a reliable substitute for the painting's exact tonal relations.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 74.73

19 / 20

Abundant Fruit

Severin Roesen

1858 · Oil on canvas · Minneapolis Institute of Art



Severin Roesen. Abundant Fruit. Severin Roesen; Minneapolis Institute of Art; Gift of Don and Diana Lee Lucker; 2005.96. Public Domain Mark 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

Roesen assembles more fruit than a casual arrangement would require, allowing whole skins, cut interiors, leaves and tendrils to compete for notice. Darkness makes the crowded display easier to distinguish. Abundance is an ordered pictorial effect: each variety has to remain sufficiently separate for the quantity to register as variety rather than a single indistinct heap.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2005.96

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Ichikawa Danjūrō V in a Shibaraku Role

Katsukawa Shunshō

c. 1788 · Hanging scroll (nikuhitsu), ink and colour on silk · Minneapolis Institute of Art



Katsukawa Shunshō. Actor Ichikawa Danjūrō V in a Shibaraku Role. Katsukawa Shunshō; Minneapolis Institute of Art; Bequest of Richard P. Gale; 74.1.110. Public Domain Mark 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The actor's red costume, kneeling pose and long sword carry the theatrical identity without an elaborate stage around them. Shunshō uses the empty ground to make the silhouette especially legible. This is a painted hanging scroll, not a woodblock print: its economy belongs to the handling of a single image as well as to the clarity of the role.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 74.1.110

Allow different works different speeds

The crowded fruit and the nearly black Reinhardt do not reward the same first glance. Let the work's contrasts determine how long it takes to distinguish its parts. This is a collection-based selection, not an account of current installation. Check the museum's live records before planning a visit around a specific object, particularly works on paper or silk.

Further reading

The Practice and Science of Drawing

Harold Speed · Read free · English

Speed’s practical account of tone and composition can be tested against the portraits and landscapes here. Start with the dark Mancini self-portrait and the pale forms of Poussin, where very different distributions of light guide recognition.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

Artline · Minneapolis Institute of Art: Masterpieces